

url4 topology — node, host, discovery, addressing, transport

Sharp definitions before the Engine grows further

STATUS	proposed — owner review; one decision left open in §5
WORK ITEM	OME-1110
DATE	2026-09-04
OWNER	Sergey Bershadsky (execution and telemetry architecture)
GRAMMAR OWNER	Kevin McDonough (URL4 spec, Parts A/B)
SPEC POINTERS	URL4.ai Specification v0.5 DRAFT, Parts A (§1) and B (§2–§8); pre-v0.5 monolith v0.2 for §9–§40

Read §0 first. Everything else is the reasoning behind one line of that table.
One decision is left open for the owner, in §5.

0. The eight answers

This document fixes the words we use for the pieces of url4. It is short on purpose. Each section states a definition, says where the spec agrees or is silent, and stops.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER
1	What is a node?	A stateless function behind a path. It takes <code>(context)!intent</code> and returns a result. Every node can evaluate a full url4 expression.
2	What is a host?	The origin <code>(scheme://authority)</code> that mounts one or more nodes at paths and answers discovery. <code>/</code> is its default node.
3	Swarm? Composition?	Not protocol words. The expression is the composition. The hosts it touches are its request tree. “Swarm” is only a deployment word for one operator’s hosts.
4	<code>.well-known</code> or OPTIONS?	Both are documented in §5 with their trade-offs. The owner picks there.
5	<code>/name</code> vs <code>url4://name</code> ?	<code>/name</code> is a node mounted on the host that is evaluating. <code>url4://name</code> is host <code>name</code> ’s default node <code>/</code> . Spec Part B §5.4 already says this.
6	Where does an ensemble run?	Wherever an evaluator runs: the SDK on a laptop, or a host. A local host may mount remote nodes under local names (proxy mounts).
7	Can I test a host first?	One fetch of the host’s capabilities document, or one OPTIONS per node (§5). A separate “plan” concept is deferred (§9).
8	Streaming fallback?	One GET asks for the richest mode; the node answers with the best it has: WebSocket, then SSE, then sync (§6). Sync is the only MUST. Async is a separate axis.

What changes against today

- The Engine becomes a url4 **host**. Today no url4 node is reachable over HTTP; the SDK’s node-to-node code is unused.
- Every node speaks the same GET. The node picks the richest delivery it supports: **WebSocket → SSE → sync**, in one round trip. Sync is the only MUST.
- Two spec words move: the spec’s Node becomes our Host; the spec’s Endpoint becomes our Node. Appendix A asks Kevin for the rename.

1. Terms

Eight words. Each has one meaning.

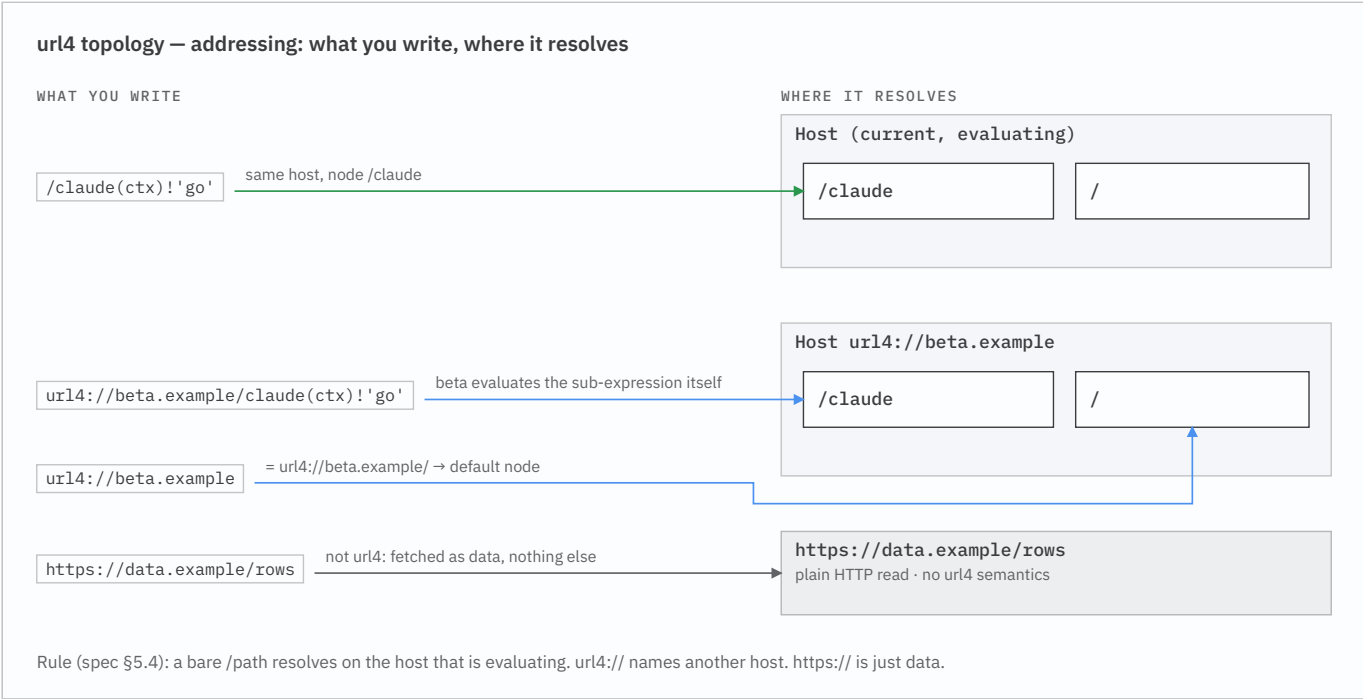
OUR WORD	MEANING	SPEC WORD TODAY	IN THE SDK	IN THE ENGINE
Node	A stateless function at a path. Accepts <code>GET <path>?q=<expr></code> , evaluates it, returns a result plus envelope.	Endpoint (Part A §1.4)	an entry in <code>Url4Node</code> ’s endpoint registry	a route such as <code>/anthropic/<model></code>
Host	An origin that mounts nodes at paths, serves <code>/</code> as the default node, and answers discovery.	Node (Part A §1.4)	<code>Url4Node</code> (the class name lags; Appendix B)	the App, after this change
Mount	The binding of a path to a node implementation: <code>local</code> (in-process), <code>command</code> (subprocess), or <code>proxy</code> (forwards to a declared remote node).	not defined	<code>endpoint()</code> , <code>[commands]</code> , —	in-process handlers only

OUR WORD	MEANING	SPEC WORD TODAY	IN THE SDK	IN THE ENGINE
Evaluator	Whatever runs an expression: resolves sources, fans out, reduces, runs the intent. Every node contains one.	“the node executes” (Part A §1)	<code>url4.dag.run</code>	<code>Url4Executor</code> in the Runner
Intent processor	The thing inside a node that turns resolved context plus intent into a result: a model call, a script, a command.	Intent processor (Part A §1.4)	endpoint handler	one <code>httpx</code> call to aigateway
Requestor	Whoever sends an expression.	Requestor (Part A §1.4)	<code>Client</code>	product client
Request tree	The hosts and nodes one expression touches. Strict tree, never a graph (v0.2 §16.1).	“request tree”, “call tree” (v0.2 §22)	the compiled DAG, per node	one run
Capabilities document	JSON a host publishes to say which nodes, mounts, features and delivery modes it offers.	named in Part A §1.4; schema unwritten (Part G)	none	none

Words we do not use in the protocol: ensembler, orchestrator, swarm, composition, plan, fusion. “Fusion” stays product copy.

2. Addressing

Three address forms. The spec fixes their meaning in Part B §3.1.1 and §5.4; we add one rule about the root.



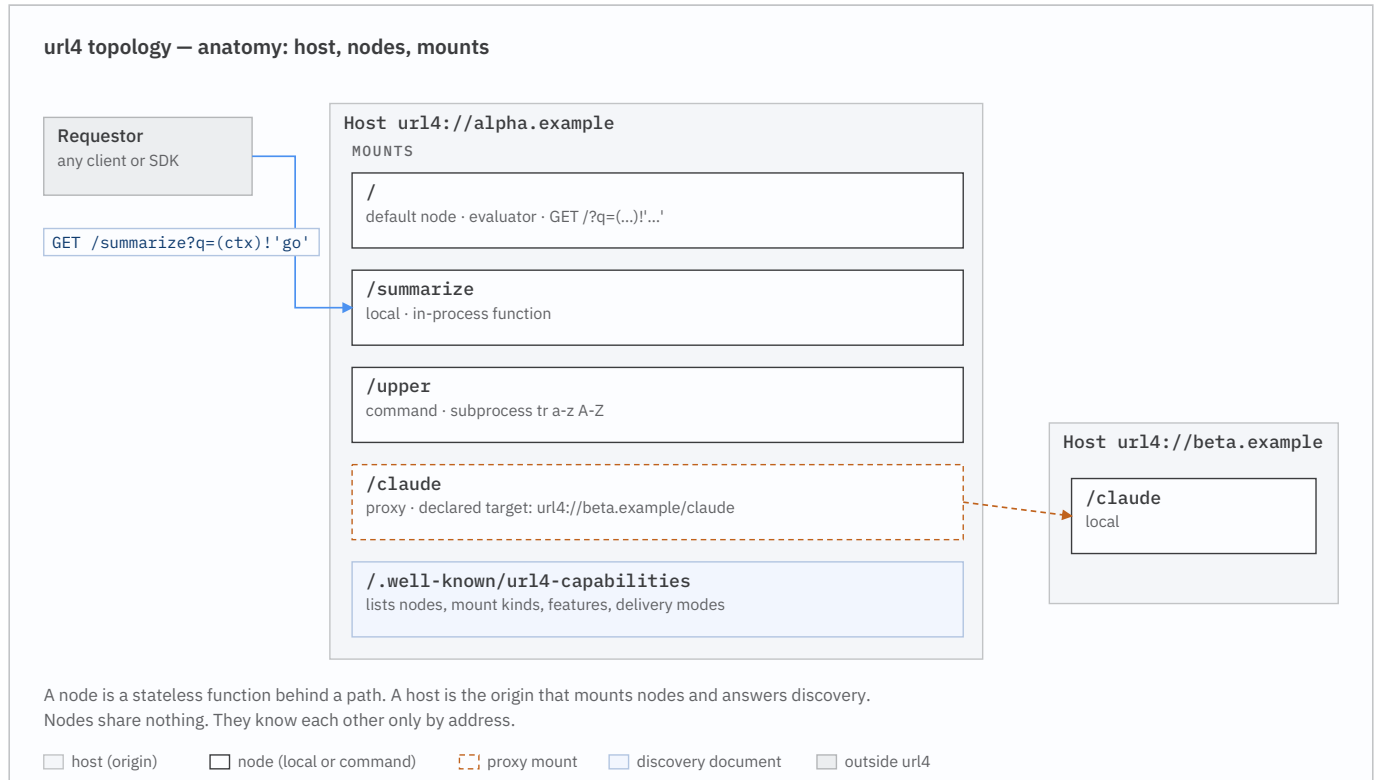
- `/claude(ctx)!'go'` — a node on the host that is evaluating. Resolves to `url4://<current host>/claude` (Part B §5.4).
- `url4://beta.example/claude(ctx)!'go'` — a node on another host. That host evaluates the sub-expression itself (Part B §3.1.1; SDK invariant OME-535).
- `url4://beta.example` — the host’s default node. **Our rule:** `url4://host` $\equiv$ `url4://host/`.
- `https://data.example/rows` — plain HTTP data. No url4 headers, no envelope, `@` is an error (Part B §3.5).

Root and version. `/` is the host’s default node. The spec makes `/v1` the protocol-version path (v0.2 §35.1). We keep both: `/` serves the current version; `/v1` is an explicit alias. The SDK’s `url4 serve (/v1)` and `Client` (default `/v1`) move to `/` (Appendix B).

Scheme inheritance. A bare relative data URI inherits the scheme of the request that carried it (Part B §5.4.1). Under `url4://` it is a url4 read; under `https://` it is a plain read.

3. Node contract

A node is a function. That is the whole idea.



A node:

- **MUST** answer `GET <path>?q=<expression>` and evaluate the expression. Every node evaluates url4; a node may walk a DAG before it reaches its own intent processor. There is one grade of node, not two.
- **MUST** be stateless per invocation. It keeps nothing between calls. Its own data is reached through `@` (Part B §5.6) and lives behind it, not in it. Multi-turn work uses an explicit session key (`;coord=`, Part B §4.2), never process memory.
- **MUST** return the envelope (v0.2 §13) and state the delivery mode it actually used (v0.2 §11.4).
- **MUST NOT** resolve `@` inside a sub-expression addressed to another host (Part B §5.6.3.1).
- **MUST** answer sync. **SHOULD** offer stream (SSE), WebSocket, and async, and advertise which (§5, §6). When asked for more than it has, it answers with the richest mode it does have; that is never an error.
- **MAY** be mounted on any host, or be its own origin. A Lambda-style function with its own URL is a host with one node.
- Speaks GET. A WebSocket, when offered, is the same GET with `Upgrade: websocket` (§6). Other verbs are 405, except the ones this document adds: `DELETE` on a run handle (§6) and, if adopted, `OPTIONS` (§5).

Nodes share nothing. A node knows another node only by address, and only because the expression named it.

4. Host contract

A host is an origin. It routes; it does not evaluate.

- Mounts one or more nodes at paths. `/` is the default node.
- Mount kinds: `local` (a function in the process), `command` (a subprocess; doctrine N4), `proxy` (forwards the sub-request verbatim to a declared target on another host).
- Declares proxy mounts with their targets in its capabilities document. Attribution and consumer disclosure (v0.2 §16.2.2) need the real target, so proxies are never hidden.
- Serves discovery (§5) and the version alias `/v1` (§2).
- A local SDK process that mounts remote nodes under local names is a host. That is how “run the ensemble on my laptop, but call `/claude` as if it were mine” works.

5. Discovery — the open decision

Two ways for a requestor to learn what a host can do. Neither exists yet: the spec names the capabilities document (Part A §1.4) but its schema is in the unwritten Part G; OPTIONS appears nowhere in the spec.

url4 topology — discovery: host document vs per-node OPTIONS

A · ONE DOCUMENT PER HOST

GET `/.well-known/url4-capabilities`

Requestor

Host

one JSON: nodes, mounts, features

one call answers “can this host run my expression?”

+ cacheable, one round-trip, lists proxy mounts with targets

– lives at the origin root only (RFC 8615): a node behind a shared gateway is visible only if that gateway lists it

B · ONE ANSWER PER NODE

Requestor

OPTIONS `/summarize`

`/summarize`

OPTIONS `/claude`

`/claude`

each node describes only itself (RFC 9110 §9.3.7)

+ works for a standalone function with no host document

– one round-trip per node; browsers and CORS middleware also use OPTIONS (preflight); CDNs do not cache it; some gateways drop it

They can coexist: the host document indexes, OPTIONS answers for one node. Section 5 leaves the choice to the owner.
Neither exists yet: the spec names the document (Part A §1.4) but its schema is in the unwritten Part G; OPTIONS appears nowhere.

	A · HOST DOCUMENTGET <code>/.well-known/url4-capabilities</code>	B · PER NODEOPTIONS <code><node></code>
“Can this host run my expression?”	one call, whole answer	one call per node named in the expression
Standalone function with its own origin	works: the document sits at that origin’s root	works
Node behind a shared, non-url4 gateway	invisible unless the gateway lists it (RFC 8615: root of the origin only)	works: the node answers for itself
Caching	ordinary GET: ETag , CDN, browser cache	not cached by CDNs or browsers

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	A · HOST DOCUMENTGET /.well-known/url4-capabilities	B · PER NODEOPTIONS /<node>
Browsers and CORS	plain GET	preflight uses the same verb; CORS middleware often answers first (RFC 9110 §9.3.7 allows a body, browsers ignore it)
Gateways and serverless platforms	fine	some strip or auto-answer OPTIONS
Proxy mount targets (attribution)	listed in one place	per node
Spec status	named; schema to write (Part G §27.2)	not in the spec

Both share one hazard: the Engine’s JWT header is called `URL4-Capability`. The document is “capabilities”. Appendix B proposes renaming the header.

Draft capabilities document (host level; a node’s OPTIONS answer is the one entry for that node):

```
{
  "url4": "0.5",
  "host": "url4://alpha.example",
  "default_node": "/",
  "nodes": {
    "/": { "mount": "local", "delivery": ["sync", "stream"],
          "features": ["nesting", "iteration", "broadcast", "self_ref"] },
    "/summarize": { "mount": "local", "delivery": ["sync"] },
    "/upper": { "mount": "command", "delivery": ["sync"] },
    "/claude": { "mount": "proxy", "target": "url4://beta.example/claude" }
  },
  "holdings": { "collections": ["default", "science"], "self_ref_support": true }
}
```

Owner decision (open). Pick one:

☐ **A only** — host document is a MUST; nothing per node.

☐ **B only** — OPTIONS per node is a MUST; no host document.

☐ **A MUST + B SHOULD** — the document indexes the host; a node may also answer OPTIONS with its own entry.

Recommendation: A MUST + B SHOULD. A alone fails the standalone-function-behind-a-gateway case; B alone fails the single-call test in answer 7.

6. Delivery and transport

The spec defines three delivery modes and a fallback rule (v0.2 §11). We adopt them, add WebSocket as a fourth answer, and make the whole ladder one request.



One request, the node picks. The evaluator sends the richest ask it can, once:

```
GET /claude?delivery=stream&q=(ctx)!'go'
Upgrade: websocket
Accept: text/event-stream, application/json
```

The node answers with the best it supports. RFC 6455 lets a WebSocket handshake ride an ordinary GET; RFC 9110 lets a server ignore Upgrade and answer normally. So one round trip covers the whole ladder:

NODE ANSWERS	MEANING	TELEMETRY TRAVELS AS
101 Switching Protocols	WebSocket : bidirectional; cancel and attach in-band	frames, same names as the SSE events
200 text/event-stream	stream : SSE on the same GET (v0.2 §11.2)	SSE events, then result, then envelope
200 application/json	sync : result plus envelope	envelope meta (§7)
202 + Location	async : run handle; GET it for status, DELETE it to cancel	on the handle

Rules:

- **sync is the only MUST**. SSE, WebSocket and async are SHOULD, advertised per node in the capabilities document (§5). A serverless function that offers only sync and SSE is conformant.

- **Ladder, not error.** WebSocket → SSE → sync. A node answering below the ask is normal; the envelope's `delivery` field says what happened (v0.2 §11.4).
- **Async is an axis, not a rung.** It is requested with `Prefer: respond-async`, or entered by the node when a sync run would outlive the timeout (v0.2 §11.4 `sync` → `async`).
- **Browsers go SSE-first.** A browser cannot attach `Accept` to a WebSocket handshake, so a browser evaluator asks for SSE and upgrades only where the capabilities document says WebSocket is offered.
- **Telemetry is always in-band.** Whatever the mode, the caller receives logs, spans and cost on the same connection or in the envelope. A remote host's own OTLP export is its business, never something the caller depends on (§7).
- **The Engine's product session** keeps its WebSocket at `/ws`. It is one instance of the WebSocket rung, not a separate protocol.

Cancel. The spec calls cancellation a gap (v0.2 §34). Over WebSocket, cancel is in-band. Otherwise it is `DELETE` on the run handle returned as `Location` (and `Link rel=self`), which the Engine already does. New terminal state `cancelled`; SSE event `request.cancelled`.

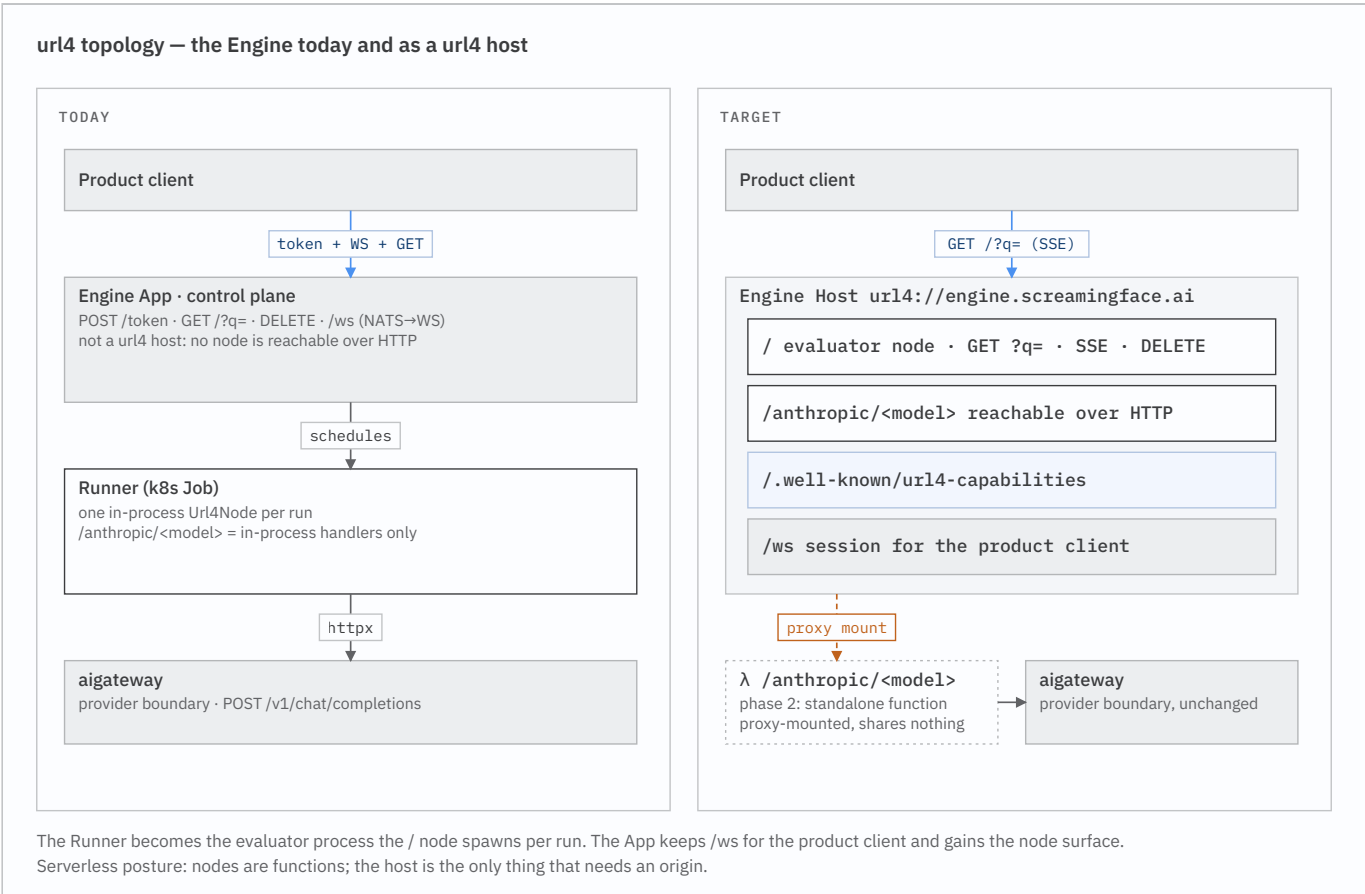
7. Telemetry

Three signals, one trace, as in the doctrine skill. What changes is where a one-shot GET puts them.

- **sync:** in the body. The envelope's `meta` carries counts, latencies and cost at the level the requestor asked for (`none`, `summary`, `full`; v0.2 §13.2). At `meta=full` a child's envelope nests in `source.envelope` (v0.2 §13.3). Each node aggregates only what it saw itself (v0.2 §14.1).
- **stream** and **WebSocket:** as events: logs, spans, `cost.usage` (self and subtree), then `result`, then `envelope`. Same names in both.
- **durable:** OTLP export to the trace backend. There is no separate “Enclave” store; the exporter superseded it.

This closes doctrine item F4. **Idempotency:** a url4 GET is idempotent in the HTTP sense (RFC 9110 §9.2.2): repeating it has no extra server-side effect. Results need not be identical; the spec's §33 conflates the two (Appendix A).

8. The Engine as a host



- **Swarm** as a protocol noun. Would need membership and trust rules that belong to the unwritten governance parts.
- **Node grades** (processor-only vs evaluator). Rejected: every node evaluates.

Appendix A — proposed spec deltas for Kevin

Each item names the anchor and the change. All are proposals.

1. **Part A §1.4 — rename.** Node → **Host** (“an origin implementing the protocol; mounts nodes”). Endpoint → **Node** (“a path on a host bound to an evaluator and an intent processor”). Add **Mount** (`local` | `command` | `proxy`), proxies declare their target).
2. **Part B §3.1.1, v0.2 §35.1 — root.** `url4://host` $\equiv$ `url4://host/`; `/` is the host’s default node at the current version; `/v1` is a version alias.
3. **Part C §11.2 — bindings.** `delivery=stream` is SSE on the same GET, requested with `Accept: text/event-stream`. A node MAY also offer WebSocket by honouring `Upgrade: websocket` on that same GET (101); frames carry the same event names.
4. **Part C §11.4 — ladder and floor.** The node answers with the richest mode it supports, WebSocket → SSE → sync, in one round trip; sync is the only MUST and `any` → `sync` is always legal. A node answering below the ask is not an error; the envelope’s `delivery` field says what happened.
5. **v0.2 §33 (Part H in v0.5) — idempotency.** Replace “the protocol does not guarantee idempotency” with: GET is idempotent per RFC 9110 §9.2.2; results are not guaranteed deterministic.
6. **v0.2 §34 (Part H in v0.5) — cancellation.** `DELETE` on the run handle (`Location`). Terminal state `cancelled`; SSE event `request.cancelled`; propagates to in-flight children.
7. **Part G §27.2 — capabilities document.** Schema as drafted in §5: `nodes` keyed by path, `mount`, `target`, `delivery`, `features`; `holdings`. Optional binding: the same entry as an `OPTIONS` body with `Content-Type: application/url4-capabilities+json`.

Appendix B — follow-up work items

To file after owner review, one per landing.

LANDING	ITEM
screamingface-engine	Host surface phase 1: discovery per §5, <code>GET /?q=</code> with SSE, <code>DELETE</code> on the run handle
screamingface-engine	Model nodes reachable over HTTP (phase 2); standalone model functions, proxy-mounted (phase 3)
screamingface-engine	Rename the <code>URL4-Capability</code> JWT header to avoid the “capabilities” collision
url4-sdk	Delivery negotiation in <code>Url4Node.asgi()</code> : <code>Upgrade</code> / <code>Accept</code> handling, SSE body, optional WebSocket answer; evaluator-side single-request ladder in <code>HttpIOLayer</code>
url4-sdk	Capabilities document and/or <code>OPTIONS</code> responder, after the §5 decision; advertise <code>delivery</code> per node
url4-sdk	<code>url4 serve</code> default path <code>/</code> ; <code>Client</code> default path <code>/</code> ; <code>/v1</code> alias
url4-sdk	<code>proxy</code> mount kind in <code>url4.toml</code>
url4-sdk	<code>Url4Node</code> → host naming retrofit with a deprecation alias
repo	Doctrine skill synced in this unit (T1, N1, F2, F4, term table)
Kevin	Review Appendix A

Appendix C — where the spec lives

- Parts A and B, v0.5 DRAFT (2026-07-10): `secondbrain/kevin-mcdonough/docs/adrs/URL4-Spec-A.md`, `URL4-Spec-B.md`.
- Parts C–I: “Not yet written” stubs (`.../adrs/site/part-c.html` ... `part-i.html`). Their content is the pre-v0.5 monolith, git `8a052dc:kevin-mcdonough/docs/adrs/URL4-Spec.md`, header v0.2. Cited here as “v0.2 §N”.
- Public docs: `public-docs/src/pages/learn/Url4Page.vue`. They use “fusion” and “typed DAG”; the spec uses neither.
- Doctrine: `.claude/skills/url4-engine/SKILL.md`, updated with this document.